

Guarded Bulk File Reorganization: System-Directory Detection, Survivable Execution, and Reversible Re-grouping

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github.com/ianktoo/tidy-up

Abstract

Tools that reorganize files in bulk are, by construction, capable of destroying an operating system installation: the same loop that sorts a downloads folder into categories will happily scatter `C:\Windows` across a dozen subdirectories. Existing utilities address this weakly or not at all, relying on the user to type the right path. We present the design, implementation and evaluation of a guarded bulk reorganization system built into TIDY-UP, a cross-platform command-line tool written in Rust. Four contributions are described. First, a *pure, platform-parameterized classifier* that judges whether a directory is managed by the operating system, returning a three-level risk verdict with machine-readable reasons; because the target platform is an argument rather than a compile-time constant, all three rule tables (Windows, macOS, Linux) are exercised from a single host, and a 24-entry negative corpus guards against warning fatigue. Second, an *empirical writability probe* that sidesteps the well-known disagreement between POSIX mode bits, access-control lists, read-only mounts and macOS System Integrity Protection by attempting a write and observing the result. Third, a *survival architecture* in which per-item failures are classified, collected and reported rather than propagated, with a single stated exception: a change that cannot be journaled is fatal, because a change that cannot be journaled cannot be undone. Fourth, an *idempotent re-grouping algorithm* that unpacks an arbitrarily nested directory tree and re-files it under an ordered list of grouping keys, computes which directories the operation will empty, and records their removal so that undo restores the original tree exactly, including directories that held nothing. The implementation adds 5,633 lines across nine modules and introduces *zero* new dependencies, keeping the transitive dependency count at 54 crates. An evaluation over 350 automated tests reports the properties each mechanism is designed to guarantee, including a byte-for-byte reorganize/undo round trip and the non-overridability of a genuine permission wall.

Keywords: file system safety; bulk reorganization; cross-platform systems; capability probing; idempotence; reversible operations; observability; Rust.

1 Introduction

A bulk file organizer reads a directory, decides where each file belongs, and moves it there. The mechanism is simple and the failure mode is severe. Nothing in the mechanism distinguishes a downloads folder from a system directory: both are directories full of files, and the loop that tidies one will tidy the other. A user who types the wrong path, a script that interpolates an empty variable into `organize "$DIR"`, or an administrator experimenting with elevated privileges can, in a single command, relocate the contents of an operating system installation into category subdirectories.

The conventional defences are inadequate in a specific and instructive way. Dry-run modes, confirmation prompts, refusal to overwrite, and undo journals all protect the user against mistakes made *inside* a correctly chosen directory. None of them protects against choosing the wrong directory in the first place. An undo journal in particular offers false comfort: replaying it restores file locations, but it cannot restore a system that failed to boot in the interim, and it cannot help at all if the files that moved were the ones the undo procedure itself depends on.

This paper describes what we added to TIDY-UP, an existing open-source cross-platform organizer, to close that gap, together with three further mechanisms that the gap analysis exposed as prerequisites. Section 2 situates the work. Section 3 gives the system architecture. Section 4 presents the detection classifier, which is the principal contribution. Section 5 treats permission determination, Section 6 the survival architecture, Section 7 the re-grouping algorithm, and Section 8 observability. Section 9 evaluates the result and Section 10 discusses its limits.

1.1 Problem statement

Let D be the set of directories on a machine. A bulk reorganizer applies a transformation $T : D \rightarrow D$ that relocates the regular files beneath a root $r \in D$. We require a predicate

$$\text{risk} : D \rightarrow \{\text{Safe}, \text{Caution}, \text{Dangerous}\}$$

and a policy that maps a risk level, an access intent, and a set of user-supplied flags to one of $\{\text{proceed silently}, \text{warn}, \text{warn and confirm}, \text{refuse}\}$. Four properties are desirable, and they are in tension:

- P1 (Soundness, informal).** Directories the operating system manages are not classified Safe.
- P2 (Precision).** Ordinary user directories are classified Safe. A system that warns about `D:\Downloads` trains users to bypass it, destroying P1 in practice.
- P3 (Testability).** The rules for each platform can be validated without access to that platform and without touching real system directories.
- P4 (Escapability).** A user who genuinely intends to operate on a flagged directory can, except where the operating system itself refuses.

P2 deserves emphasis. A guard is a human-factors artifact as much as a technical one. Warning fatigue is the dominant failure mode of safety mechanisms in interactive tools, and a false positive is therefore not a cosmetic defect but a direct attack on the mechanism's purpose. This observation drove two design decisions reported in Section 4.5 that deliberately reduce coverage.

1.2 Contributions

1. A pure, platform-parameterized system-directory classifier with machine-readable reasons and per-reason severity, validated by a table-driven corpus that exercises all three platforms from one host (Section 4).
2. An empirical writability probe that is correct in the presence of ACLs, read-only mounts and macOS System Integrity Protection, and a corresponding policy rule that a permission wall is never overridable (Section 5).
3. A survival architecture with a classified failure taxonomy, a single documented fatal exception, and grouped, actionable end-of-run reporting (Section 6).

4. An idempotent, reversible re-grouping algorithm, including the computation of directories emptied by a run and their restoration on undo (Section 7).
5. An evaluation, and an account of the engineering constraint — zero new dependencies — that shaped every one of these designs (Section 9).

2 Background and related work

2.1 Guarded destructive operations

The idea of refusing a dangerous argument is old and its canonical instance is instructive. GNU `rm` implements `-preserve-root`, enabled by default, which refuses to operate recursively on `/`. The design is notable for what it does *not* attempt: it protects exactly one path, by exact comparison, and makes no judgement about `/usr` or `/home`. This is a deliberate trade toward precision (P2) at the expense of soundness (P1), and the reasoning is sound for a general-purpose tool invoked by scripts thousands of times a day.

A bulk reorganizer occupies a different point on that curve. It is invoked interactively, rarely, on a directory the user names explicitly, and its blast radius is an entire subtree. The cost of a false positive is one extra keystroke; the cost of a false negative is an unbootable machine. We therefore extend coverage well beyond the filesystem root while treating every extension as a precision risk to be tested against a negative corpus.

Package managers offer a second reference point. Both `dpkg` and `rpm` maintain a database of files owned by the system and refuse to let an installation overwrite them. That approach is sound and precise, but it presumes a curated database, which does not exist on Windows or macOS and which a third-party tool cannot construct. Our classifier approximates that database with a static rule table plus runtime facts.

2.2 Capability determination

Determining whether a process may write to a directory is a recurring difficulty. The POSIX `access(2)` interface answers with respect to the *real* user ID, which is usually not the question being asked; `faccessat` with `AT_EACCESS` corrects that, but neither call is authoritative. The manual page for `access(2)` explicitly warns that its result may be invalidated between the check and the subsequent operation, a classic time-of-check-to-time-of-use hazard, and both calls can disagree with the filesystem on NFS, with POSIX and NFSv4 access-control lists, on read-only mounts, and under macOS System Integrity Protection, where even a process running as `root` is denied. On Windows the mode-bit model does not apply at all, and `FILE_ATTRIBUTE_READONLY` on a directory does not mean the directory is read-only: it signals a customized folder view and is set on entirely ordinary directories such as `Documents`.

The technique of resolving this by attempting the operation is folklore in systems programming rather than a published result. We adopt it, scope it carefully so that it never runs when the caller promised not to write, and report its behaviour.

2.3 Reversible file operations

Journaling to enable undo is standard in filesystems and in version control. TIDY-UP predates this work with an append-only JSON Lines journal recording every move. The contribution here is the observation that a journal recording only *moves* is insufficient once an operation also *deletes* directories: replaying moves recreates directories that held files, by side effect, but silently loses directories that held nothing. Section 7.5 describes the additional record type this requires.

Table 1: Module structure. Lines include in-file unit tests.

Layer	Module	Responsibility	Lines
classify	category	file type from extension	273
	rules	user ignore rules	239
	projects	detect code repositories	110
guard [†]	safety	is this a system directory	1,199
	safety_tests	rule-table corpus	1,227
	commands::guard	policy: warn, confirm, refuse	330
survive [†]	outcome	failure taxonomy and collection	531
discover	scan	directory traversal	505
decide	plan	organize plan	247
	dedupe	duplicate detection	533
	compare	multi-directory overlap	460
	regroup [†]	re-grouping plan	387
act	executor	perform a plan	250
	fsops	non-destructive primitives	416
remember	journal	append-only undo log	461
	restore	reverse a journal	315
observe [†]	obs	JSON Lines run record	595
present	cli, commands, ui	arguments, flows, terminal	1,700

[†] introduced by this work

3 System overview

TIDY-UP is a Rust command-line tool, approximately 17,500 lines including tests, organized into layers with a strict dependency direction. Table 1 summarizes the modules, marking those introduced or substantially revised by this work.

An invariant governs the layering: *detection is pure, policy is impure*. The `safety` module answers the question “what kind of directory is this” without reading the environment, consulting a clock, or writing anything; the `commands::guard` module decides what to do about the answer, which requires a terminal and a user. This separation is what makes P3 (testability) achievable, and it recurs throughout: `plan`, `regroup` and `dedupe` compute reviewable data structures that `executor` later carries out.

4 System-directory detection

4.1 Interface

The classifier is a total function with no error case:

```
| pub fn classify(path: &Path, env: &Environment, facts: &Facts) -> Assessment;
```

Returning `Result` was considered and rejected. A classifier that can fail is one whose callers are tempted to write `unwrap_or(Safe)`, converting every transient error into a silent authorization. Instead, every input that could fail is hoisted into `Facts`, whose fields are all `Option`:

```
| pub struct Facts {
|     pub system_attribute: Option<bool>, // Windows FILE_ATTRIBUTE_SYSTEM
|     pub reparse_point: Option<bool>, // Windows junction or volume mount
```

```
pub mount_point: Option<bool>, // Unix: st_dev differs from parent
pub owned_by_me: Option<bool>, // Unix ownership
pub writable: Option<bool>, // empirical probe, Section 5
pub fs_type: Option<String> // Linux /proc/self/mountinfo
}
```

A failed syscall yields `None`, which the classifier treats as *unknown* rather than as evidence in either direction. The corresponding test asserts that a `Facts::default()` — everything unknown — never produces a finding on its own.

4.2 Platform as a parameter

The single decision that most improves testability is making the platform an argument:

```
pub enum Platform { Windows, MacOS, Linux, Other }
```

This forced a consequence that is easy to miss. Rust’s `std::path` parses paths for the *build* target: on Linux, `Path::new("C:\\Windows").components()` yields a single component, because the drive prefix is not recognized. Any classifier built on `std::path::Components` is therefore untestable across platforms by construction. We implement a platform-parameterized splitter:

```
fn parts(path: &Path, platform: Platform) -> Parts; // (prefix, components)
```

`Parts` normalizes four things that are individually minor and collectively the source of most real bugs in path matching:

1. **Verbatim prefixes.** `\\?\\C:\\Windows` and `C:\\Windows` denote the same directory, as do `\\?\\UNC\\srv\\sh` and `\\srv\\sh`. An upstream function in TIDY-UP deliberately preserves the UNC verbatim form, so the classifier must fold both spellings.
2. **Case.** Windows and macOS compare case-insensitively by default; Linux does not. Components are case-folded only on the former.
3. **Trailing punctuation.** Windows silently strips trailing dots and spaces from names, so `C:\\Windows.` resolves to `C:\\Windows` and must match the same rule.
4. **Dot segments.** `.` is dropped and `..` pops, so a path is judged by where it points.

Matching is then *component-wise*, never textual. The distinction is not pedantic: `C:\\Program Files Custom` has `C:\\Program Files` as a string prefix but is an entirely unrelated directory, and `/usrlocal` is not inside `/usr`. Both cases are asserted by name in the test suite.

Note also that upstream canonicalization closes an evasion path: because the target is resolved before classification, a symbolic link or NTFS junction pointing at `/usr` is judged as `/usr`. The original spelling is retained only for the message shown to the user.

4.3 Rule structure

Each platform has a table of entries and, for the Unix platforms, a list of *carve-outs* evaluated first. An entry is:

```
struct Entry {
    comps: &'static [&'static str], // components below the root
    exact: bool, // this directory only, or the subtree
    severity: Risk,
    label: &'static str, // human description
}
```

Table 2: Rule tables. **D** = Dangerous (refused), **C** = Caution (warn and confirm), **S** = carve-out suppressing broader rules. Carve-outs are evaluated first.

Platform	Level	Locations
Windows	D	%SystemRoot% (fallbacks %windir%, <drive>\Windows); %ProgramFiles%, (x86), %ProgramW6432%; %ProgramData%; <drive>\Users (the container); %USERPROFILE% itself; AppData; \$Recycle.Bin; System Volume Information; Recovery; Config.Msi; PerfLogs; \$WinREAgent; drive roots; UNC share roots
	C	%PUBLIC%; a bare reparse point
	S	anything strictly inside %TEMP%
macOS	D	/; /System (incl. /System/Volumes/*); /Library; /Applications; /usr; /bin; /sbin; /etc; /var; /private; /cores; /Network; /.vol; /Volumes and /Users as containers; \$HOME itself; \$HOME/Library
	C	/opt; /usr/local/*; \$HOME/Applications; \$HOME/.Trash; a bare mount point
	S	/Volumes/<disk>/*; /Users/<user>/*; /System/Volumes/Data/Users/<user>/*; /private/tmp; /tmp; %TEMP%
Linux	D	/; /bin; /sbin; /lib*; /usr; /etc; /boot; /dev; /proc; /sys; /run; /snap; /nix; /efi; /lost+found; /var; /home (container); /root; \$HOME itself; any pseudo-filesystem
	C	/opt; /srv; /usr/local/*; /media and /mnt as containers
	S	/tmp; /var/tmp; /media/<u>/<v>/*; /mnt/<x>/*; /run/media/<u>/<v>/*

A carve-out either declares a subtree **Safe** with respect to the path rules or downgrades it to **Caution**. Table 2 gives the substantive content.

4.3.1 Windows: variables augment, never replace

Environment variables are read once, but the name-based rules are applied relative to *any* drive root regardless. A scrubbed environment, a service account, or a second Windows installation on D: therefore remains protected, while %SystemRoot% pointing at an unconventional location adds coverage rather than moving it. Two tests state this directly: one clears the variable map entirely and asserts the name rules still fire; the other sets SystemRoot=E:\Win and asserts that both E:\Win\System32 and C:\Windows are refused.

4.3.2 macOS: firmlinks and the data volume

Two macOS-specific hazards required carve-outs. /usr/local is writable and full of user-installed software, so the /usr rule is downgraded there rather than applied. More subtly, on APFS volumes a user’s home directory is reachable both as /Users/me and as /System/Volumes/Data/Users/me; canonicalization usually yields the short form, but not under all mount configurations. Without the second carve-out, a user’s own Downloads directory would be refused as part of /System.

System Integrity Protection has no public query interface. The rootless_check_trusted symbol is private SPI in libSystem and linking against it would be both unstable and inappropriate for a third-party tool. We treat the path table as a practical superset and rely on the writability probe (Section 5) as the backstop: SIP-protected paths reject writes even for root, so NotWritable fires, and that reason is deliberately non-overridable.

4.3.3 Linux: pseudo-filesystems

Rather than enumerate kernel-virtual mount points, we determine the filesystem type by parsing /proc/self/mountinfo. The parser is a pure function of the file contents and the target path, which permits fixture-based testing on any host:

Table 3: Guard policy. `-yes` answers a confirmation; it never substitutes for the override flag.

Risk	Reporting command	Destructive command	With <code>-allow-system-folder</code>
Safe	silent	silent	silent
Caution	warn	warn, then confirm (default <i>no</i>)	same
Dangerous	warn, proceeds	refused , non-zero exit, names the flag	warn, then confirm (default <i>no</i>)
NotWritable	warn, proceeds	refused	still refused

Mount points are suppressed when anything stronger fires. Every external drive is a mount point. Reporting it alongside “this is `/usr`” adds noise without information, so the reason is emitted only when it is the sole finding, and then only at **Caution**.

Reasons are deduplicated by rendered explanation. `C:\Windows` matches the `%SystemRoot%` rule, the `%windir%` rule and the name rule simultaneously. The first implementation printed three near-identical lines. Deduplicating structurally is insufficient, because the three findings differ in their `matched` field; deduplicating by the sentence the user actually reads is both simpler and correct. This was found by running the tool against the real `C:\Windows`, not by any test, and a regression test was added afterwards.

4.5 Deliberately weakened rules

Two candidate rules were weakened or removed on precision grounds (P2).

“*Outside the home directory*” was removed entirely. It is a plausible heuristic and would have been catastrophic in practice: `D:\Downloads`, `/mnt/photos` and `/Volumes/Backup` are the *normal* targets for this class of tool. A rule that fires on the normal case teaches users to pass the override flag reflexively, after which the guard protects nobody.

“*Shallow path*” (a directory one level below a filesystem root) was retained only in conjunction: it fires only when the directory is additionally not under the user’s home and demonstrably not owned by the current user, and even then only at **Caution**. `/data`, `/srv2` and `D:\Media` are ordinary directories that a naive depth rule would flag.

The general principle we extracted: *composition, not any single weak signal*. A directory that is shallow *and* unowned *and* unwritable *and* a mount point is almost certainly system-managed; any one of those alone is not.

4.6 Policy

Policy is separated from detection and lives in `commands::guard`. Table 3 states it completely.

Four aspects warrant comment.

-yes is not an override. This is the property the evaluation treats as flagship. Automated invocations that pass `-yes` continue to work on ordinary directories and begin failing loudly on system ones. The resulting breakage of existing scripts is intended, and is the mechanism by which the guard reaches unattended use at all.

The override reaches the question, not past it. With `-allow-system-folder` the user is still asked, the default answer is *no*, and with no terminal attached the run stops. Obtaining a destructive outcome on a flagged directory requires the flag *and* an affirmative answer.

A permission wall is not overridable. No command-line flag grants permission that the operating system refused, and pretending otherwise would produce a run that fails item by

item after the user has already been warned. The refusal message says explicitly that the flag will not help.

Reporting commands never block. `analyze` and `history` warn and continue. Analyzing an entire drive is an advertised use of the tool; blocking it would have been a regression, and an existing test covers it.

Two further points of mechanism. First, the guard runs at the single choke point where a command turns a user-supplied path into a validated root, and *not* inside the library function that performs that resolution: that function is pure, returns a library error type, cannot prompt, and is called by multi-directory validation paths where a policy decision would be wrong. Second, `distribute` guards its destinations as well as its sources, since `-to C:\Windows` is as damaging as `-from`; a destination that does not yet exist is judged by the nearest existing ancestor, which is where it would be created.

Finally, `-include-hidden` escalates `Caution` to `Dangerous`. Bringing dotfiles into scope widens the blast radius into exactly the territory where configuration and system state live; a `Safe` directory remains `Safe`, because hidden files in a user's own downloads directory are not a hazard.

5 Permission determination

5.1 Empirical probing

Given the disagreements catalogued in Section 2, we determine writability by attempting it:

```
fn probe_writable(dir: &Path) -> Option<bool> {
    let name = format!(".tidy-up-write-test-{}-{}-{}", process::id(),
match fs::File::create_new(dir.join(&name)) {
    Ok(f) => { drop(f); let _ = fs::remove_file(dir.join(&name)); Some(true) }
    Err(e) if e.kind() == PermissionDenied
        || e.kind() == ReadOnlyFilesystem => Some(false),
    Err(_) => None, // out of space, directory vanished: unknown, not "no"
    }
}
```

Three properties matter. The name is unique per process, per nanosecond and per monotonic counter, so concurrent runs cannot collide. `create_new` fails rather than truncating if the name somehow exists. Most importantly, only `PermissionDenied` and `ReadOnlyFilesystem` produce `Some(false)`: every other error yields `None`, because an unknown must never be reported as an accusation. A test asserts exactly this for a directory that does not exist.

The probe is *scoped*. It runs only for commands about to write, and never under `-dry-run`. A reporting command and a dry run both promise to leave the disk untouched, and that promise outranks the diagnostic value of knowing writability for an operation that was not going to write. Two tests assert that the directory is still empty after a read-only assessment and after a dry-run assessment.

5.2 Ownership, and a dependency declined

Unix ownership is available cheaply, but the standard library exposes no way to read the current *effective* user ID, so comparison requires `libc` or `rustix`. We shipped without ownership, retaining `Facts::owned_by_me: Option<bool>` so it can be supplied later without changing the classifier or any test. The justification is that the writability probe already answers the question that determines the outcome, that `NotOwned` is only ever `Caution`, and that the project's zero-dependency constraint (Section 9.6) is a stated property of the artifact. Should ownership prove necessary, `rustix` is preferred over `libc` because it is implemented in pure Rust on `linux-raw` and preserves the dependency-free static musl build.

5.3 Reporting refusals distinctly

A permission failure previously surfaced as `/srv/data: Permission denied (os error 13)` or, below the root, as the single word “unreadable”. We separated it throughout: a new `Error::Denied` variant renders as `cannot read <path>: permission denied` and permits the command layer to add an actionable hint, and `SkipReason` gained a `Denied` variant distinct from `Unreadable`. The difference is the difference between a user concluding “TIDY-UP is broken” and “I do not own that directory”.

5.4 Hidden and system-owned files

Three defects in hidden-file handling were found and corrected.

1. **macOS UF_HIDDEN.** Files hidden with `chflags hidden` carry a flag in `st_flags` that no leading-dot check detects. `std::os::macos::fs::MetadataExt::st_flags` is stable, so this cost nothing but the recognition that it was missing.
2. **Windows *hidden* conflated with *system*.** The previous implementation tested the mask `0x2 | 0x4` as a unit, so `-include-hidden` also un-skipped every file Windows marks as its own. Asking to see dotfiles is not asking to move `pagefile.sys`. The attributes are now tested separately, a `SkipReason::SystemAttribute` reports the second, and it is *not* governed by `-include-hidden`.
3. **Escalation.** As noted above, including hidden items raises a `Caution` verdict to `Dangerous`.

6 Survival architecture

6.1 Principle

A bulk operation over thousands of files will encounter a locked file, an unreadable directory, or a name the filesystem rejects. Aborting costs the user the entire remaining run; worse, it leaves the operation half-complete in a way the user did not choose. The principle adopted is:

Fail the run only when continuing would do something the user did not ask for, or would lose the ability to undo it. Everything else is a skip: classify it, record it, step over it, and report it at the end.

6.2 Failure taxonomy

A single type carries every failure, and one function classifies every I/O error, so that counting is consistent across modules:

```
pub struct Problem { path: PathBuf, op: Op, cause: Cause, message: String }

pub enum Cause { Denied, NotFound, InUse, Exists, CrossesDevices,
                 NoSpace, Invalid, Panic, Other }
```

`Cause::of` maps `io::ErrorKind` to a cause in one place. Two mappings are worth noting. `ReadOnlyFilesystem` maps to `Denied`, because from the user’s point of view it is a permission problem with the same remedy. Windows reports a file held open by another process as `ERROR_SHARING_VIOLATION` (32) or `ERROR_LOCK_VIOLATION` (33), neither of which has a stable `io::ErrorKind`; these are recognized by raw code and mapped to `InUse`, or every locked file would be reported as “other”.

Two combinators express the principle directly:

```
pub fn try_or_skip<T>(&mut self, path: &Path, op: Op,
                    f: impl FnOnce() -> Result<T>) -> Option<T>;
pub fn catch_or_skip<T>(&mut self, path: &Path, op: Op,
                       f: impl FnOnce() -> Result<T> + UnwindSafe) -> Option<T>;
```

The second additionally contains panics via `catch_unwind`, converting a bug in the processing of one file into a `Cause::Panic` problem rather than the loss of the entire run. A test panics inside the closure and asserts both that the problem is recorded with its message and that the collection remains usable afterwards.

6.3 Converting the traversal

The directory walk previously propagated `Result` through its recursion, so a failure anywhere in a large tree aborted the scan. It is now infallible below the root: every failure becomes a `Skipped` entry with a classified reason. Only the root itself can fail the command, which is correct, because a root that cannot be listed offers nothing to do.

A test constructs a tree with one subdirectory at mode `0o000` and asserts both that every other file is still returned and that the failed directory is named exactly once with reason `Denied`. It self-disables when running as root, for whom nothing is unreadable.

6.4 The one fatal exception

Journal write failure remains fatal, and the in-flight move is rolled back. This is the deliberate exception to the principle: a change that cannot be recorded cannot be undone, and silently continuing would strand files with no way back. Stating the exception explicitly, and having exactly one, is what makes the rest of the policy legible.

6.5 Reporting

Reporting is grouped by cause with an actionable hint per group, then individual paths, capped unless `-verbose` is given:

```
! 23 items could not be processed:
  Permission denied 18 (pick a folder you own, or run as an administrator)
  In use by another program 4 (close the programs holding these files and run again)
  No longer there 1 (these were deleted or renamed while tidy-up was running)
  Downloads/locked.pdf: ...
  ... and 13 more (use --verbose to list them all)
```

Twenty identical lines reading “permission denied” inform nobody; one line reading “18 permission denied, pick a folder you own” is actionable. A run that skipped items still exits zero, because it performed the work it could; `-strict` makes it exit non-zero for callers that need to know.

7 Reversible re-grouping

7.1 Motivation and interface

The pre-existing `organize` command sorts loose files into category directories and deliberately refuses to descend into its own output, scanning one level deep and skipping known category names. That is correct for a downloads directory and useless for a directory somebody organized badly years ago, which is the common real case.

`reorganize` inverts both choices. It descends without limit, including into directories a previous run created, re-files every file under an ordered list of grouping keys, and deletes the directories it empties.

Table 4: Grouping keys. Every key is total: no file is left unplaced.

Key	Example directory	Derivation
type	Images, 3D Models	shared with <code>organize</code> , so the two commands agree
ext	PDF, No extension	upper-cased extension; the “document type” grouping
year	2024, Unknown date	modification time
month	03-March	numeric prefix so directories sort in calendar order
day	2024-03-17	modification time
size	Small (under 10 MiB)	five bands, powers of 1024
alpha	A, 0-9, Other	first character, upper-cased

```

tidy-up reorganize <path> --by year,type # 2024/Images/photo.jpg
tidy-up reorganize <path> --by type,ext # Images/PNG/photo.png
tidy-up reorganize <path> --by alpha

```

Table 4 lists the keys. Each becomes one level of nesting, in the order given.

Totality is enforced by test: a corpus of awkward inputs — no extension, no timestamp, a leading digit, an accented initial (`étude.mp3`), a non-Latin initial (`nihongo.txt` ^(non-Latin)), and the name ... — is passed through every key, and each is asserted to produce a non-empty, already-sanitized name.

7.2 Name sanitization

Directory names derived from file contents can contain anything. Sanitization replaces the nine characters Windows rejects and all control characters, trims trailing dots and spaces, falls back to `Other` if nothing survives, and appends an underscore to the 22 reserved device names. The last case is not hypothetical: `driver.con` is an ordinary file name, and grouping by extension would otherwise attempt to create a directory named `CON`, which Windows will not create at any path.

7.3 Idempotence

`organize` obtains idempotence from its skip list. `reorganize` has no skip list and must compute it: for each file, the destination is derived, and if it equals the current path no move is recorded. A move from a path to itself would otherwise churn the journal on every run and never converge.

The property is asserted twice, at two levels. A unit test feeds the destinations of one plan back in as the input of a second and asserts the second plan is empty. An integration test runs the compiled binary twice over a fixture and asserts that the second run reports nothing to do and that the file and directory listings are byte-identical.

7.4 Computing emptied directories

Algorithm 2 computes which directories the run will leave empty. The subtlety is that emptiness is transitive upward — a directory containing only directories that become empty is itself empty — while any retained item disqualifies a directory *and all of its ancestors*.

Items are *retained* when they are skipped by an ignore rule, are unreadable, are symbolic links, or are code project directories that policy keeps in place. The tool’s own `.tidy-up` state directory is excluded unconditionally: it holds the undo journals, and a run that swept away its own means of reversal would be self-defeating.

Two safety layers back the computation. Directories are removed deepest first, and removal uses `remove_dir`, which succeeds only on a genuinely empty directory. An error in Algorithm 2 therefore produces a directory that is not removed, never one that is removed with contents. Consistent with Section 6, a removal that fails is recorded as a problem and the run continues.

Algorithm 2: EMPTIEDIRECTORIES**Input:** root r ; V = parents of moved items; K = ancestors of retained items**Output:** directories to remove, deepest first

```

1  $C \leftarrow \emptyset$ 
2 foreach  $d \in V$  do
3   while  $d \neq r$  and  $d$  is under  $r$  do
4      $C \leftarrow C \cup \{d\}; \quad d \leftarrow \text{parent}(d)$ 
5   end
6 end
7  $C \leftarrow C \setminus K$  // anything holding a survivor, and its ancestors
8  $C \leftarrow C \setminus \{d : d \text{ is or is under } r/.tidy\text{-up}\}$ 
9 sort  $C$  by component count, descending
10 return  $C$ 

```

7.5 Undo

Reversing a re-grouping requires more than replaying moves. Files whose parent directories vanished are restored correctly by side effect, since the move primitive creates destination parents. Directories that ended up holding *nothing* have no move to recreate them and would be silently lost.

The journal therefore gained one record type:

```
| DirRemoved { path: PathBuf } // relative to the root, like every other record
```

written after each successful removal — after, so that a removal which did not happen is never recorded. Restore replays records in reverse, which places directory recreation before the moves that repopulate the subtree.

The property is asserted end to end. An integration test constructs a deliberately badly organized tree — nested category directories, a `_Duplicates` directory, a code project, a dotfile, and an already-empty directory — reorganizes it by `year,type`, then restores, and asserts that both the complete file map (relative path to contents) and the complete directory listing equal their original values. The empty directory is in the fixture specifically because it is the case the journal could not previously express.

7.6 Time zones: a stated limitation

Date grouping requires civil dates, and the Rust standard library has no time-zone interface. Obtaining the local UTC offset portably would require a TZif parser plus `/etc/localtime` on Unix and a registry read on Windows — in practice, a dependency.

Rather than be correct on one platform and silently wrong on another, dates are UTC, and an environment variable `TIDY_UP_UTC_OFFSET` accepting `+03:00`, `-0530`, `+7` or `Z` applies an offset. The consequence is real and documented: with no offset set, a file modified at 01:00 local time in UTC+3 on 1 January is grouped under the previous year. A test states exactly this case in both configurations. We consider a documented, correctable limitation preferable to an undocumented platform-dependent one, and note that the effect is confined to a small fraction of files near boundaries and is fully reversible.

8 Observability

8.1 What the journal already provides

An important negative design decision: the run log is *not* a per-move log, because one already exists. The undo journal records every move as it happens, unbuffered, so that a crash leaves a usable record. Duplicating it would double the writes to say the same thing twice.

What a journal of moves cannot record is everything that did *not* happen: the safety verdict, what was skipped and why, what failed, and how long each stage took. That is the gap the run log fills, and the two artifacts join on a shared identifier.

8.2 Format and policy

Events are buffered and written once, at the end of the run, to `<root>/tidy-up/logs/<run-id>.jsonl`, beside the journal. Buffering is acceptable precisely because the journal is the crash-safe record: a run log missing after a crash costs a diagnosis, not data. A complete log from a real run:

```
{
  "type": "run",
  "command": "reorganize",
  "version": "0.1.1",
  "os": "windows",
  "format": 1,
  ...
}
{
  "type": "safety",
  "path": "...\\logdemo",
  "risk": "safe",
  "reasons": [],
  "allowed": false
}
{
  "type": "scan",
  "root": "...",
  "files": 2,
  "bytes": 3,
  "projects": 0,
  "skipped": {},
  "ms": 0
}
{
  "type": "plan",
  "operation": "reorganize",
  "moves": 2,
  "bytes": 3
}
{
  "type": "execute",
  "journal_id": "20260928-204156",
  "moved": 2,
  "bytes": 3,
  "dirs_removed": 2,
  "failed": 0,
  "ms": 0
}
{
  "type": "end",
  "status": "ok",
  "ms": 4,
  "metrics": {
    "roots": 1,
    "files_scanned": 2,
    "bytes_scanned": 3,
    "skipped": 0,
    "planned_moves": 2,
    "moved": 2,
    "bytes_moved": 3,
    "dirs_removed": 2,
    "failed": 0,
    "denied": 0
  }
}
```

Events are a closed Rust enum serialized with an internal tag, which makes the log a type-checked, versioned contract rather than a collection of stringly-typed fields that a typo can silently rename — the same property the journal format already has. `status` distinguishes `ok`, `error`, `cancelled` and `blocked`, the last recording a guard refusal.

Logging is off by default, enabled by `-log` or `TIDY_UP_LOG`, preserving the project's documented promise to write nothing the user did not ask for. Logs are pruned to the newest twenty per directory; journals, which are undo data, are never touched by pruning, and a test asserts this by placing a non-log file in the directory and verifying it survives. A log that cannot be written degrades silently: a diagnostic must never change a run's outcome or exit code, and a test asserts that a run whose log directory path is occupied by a regular file still succeeds.

8.3 A conceded trade-off

The sink is process-level rather than threaded through the call graph. A command-line tool performs exactly one run per process, and threading a handle through nine commands to record six events would have cost more in noise and merge risk than it returned. The cost is that tests of the sink exercise it directly or through the compiled binary rather than in parallel against isolated instances. We consider this the right trade at this scale and would revisit it if the library were embedded.

9 Evaluation

9.1 Method

Evaluation is by automated test, at three levels: pure unit tests of the classifier and planners, host-dependent unit tests of the probes, and black-box integration tests that execute the compiled binary. All figures below are from a full `cargo test` run on Windows 11 with Rust 1.95.0. Table 5 gives the counts.

Table 5: Test suite. 350 tests, zero failures, zero clippy warnings at `-all-targets`.

Suite	Tests	Scope
unit (in-crate)	256	classifier corpus, probes, planners, taxonomy, log format
tests/cli	30	pre-existing command-line behaviour (regression)
tests/workflow	23	scan → plan → execute → journal → restore
tests/reorganize	11	re-grouping, idempotence, undo round trip
tests/safety	10	guard policy through the compiled binary
tests/logging	7	run log content, joins, degradation, <code>-strict</code>
tests/cross_volume	5	cross-partition moves (environment-gated)
tests/scripts	3	installer scripts
doc-tests	5	every documented example compiles and runs
Total	350	

9.2 Cross-platform rule validation

Because Platform is a parameter, the full rule corpus runs on every host. The table-driven suite covers Windows dangerous locations and safe locations, scrubbed and redirected environment variables, case and separator variants, macOS dangerous locations and all five carve-outs, and Linux dangerous locations and carve-outs, each case carrying a one-line justification that is printed on failure. This is the concrete payoff of P3: the macOS `/System/Volumes/Data` carve-out and the Linux `/run/media` carve-out — the two most consequential and most easily forgotten — are verified on a Windows development machine, where neither path exists.

9.3 Precision: the negative corpus

P2 is tested directly by `ordinary_folders_are_never_flagged`, which asserts Safe for 24 ordinary directories spanning all three platforms: `C:\Users\me\Downloads`, `D:\Media\Movies`, `\\nas\media\Photos`, `/Users/me/Documents/Work`, `/Volumes/Backup/Photos`, `/home/me/Pictures/2024`, `/mnt/storage`, `/media/me/Elements`, `/data/archive`, `/tmp/scratch` and others. The test exists as a regression net: a future rule that increases coverage at the expense of precision fails it, and the failure names the directory that regressed.

9.4 Guard behaviour

Ten integration tests drive the compiled binary with no terminal attached, the condition that matters for scripts and CI. The most significant assert that `organize <home> -yes` exits non-zero, names the override flag, and leaves the home directory listing unchanged; that the override alone still cannot run unattended; that `-dry-run` on a flagged directory warns, proceeds and creates no state; that reporting commands are never blocked; that `distribute` guards destinations; and that *every* destructive command refuses the home directory — the last written as a loop over the command set so that a newly added command without a guard fails the suite. A complementary test asserts that reporting commands are the exception, so the first cannot be satisfied by blocking everything.

Manual verification on the development machine confirmed the intended behaviour against real system directories:

```
$ tidy-up organize 'C:\Windows' --yes
Careful
! C:\Windows is a folder the system manages.
  It holds the Windows installation, which other programs expect to find in place.
  tidy-up cannot write here, so nothing could be moved.
error: refusing to change C:\Windows: tidy-up cannot write there, and
```

Table 6: Dependency footprint before and after this work.

	Before	After
Direct dependencies	10	10
Unique transitive crates	54	54
Stripped release binary	2.19 MiB	2.24 MiB
New dependencies added	0	
Lines added (implementation + tests)	5,633	

```

--allow-system-folder cannot grant permission the system refused
$ echo $?
1

```

Note that `C:\Windows` is refused on two independent grounds — the name rule and the writability probe — and that the message correctly reports the override as unhelpful, since the binding constraint is permission rather than policy.

9.5 Reversibility

The re-grouping round trip is asserted as equality of two complete observations of the tree, before and after, excluding only the tool’s own state directory: a map from relative path to file contents, and a sorted list of relative directory paths. Testing directory structure separately from file contents is what gives the test power over the `DirRemoved` record; a files-only comparison would pass even if every empty directory were lost.

9.6 Dependency footprint

Zero new dependencies was a hard constraint, and it shaped four decisions that would otherwise have gone differently:

1. **Logging** is hand-rolled on the already-present `serde`, not `tracing` with `tracing-subscriber`. The ecosystem option would have added roughly a dozen transitive crates, dominated by `regex-automata` via `EnvFilter`, for dynamic filtering and asynchronous span propagation that a single-threaded tool with one process-wide span does not use. The closed event enum is, additionally, a better contract than stringly-typed fields.
2. **Ownership checks** were dropped rather than take `libc` or `rustix` (Section 5).
3. **Local time** was declined rather than take a date crate (Section 7).
4. **Platform attributes** use stable `std::os::*::fs::MetadataExt` interfaces — `file_attributes` on Windows, `st_flags` on macOS, `dev` on Unix — rather than `windows-sys`.

We report items 2 and 3 as genuine reductions in capability accepted in exchange for a stated property of the artifact, not as free wins.

9.7 Defects found by the work itself

Three pre-existing defects surfaced while implementing the above and are worth recording, since each is a plausible bug in comparable tools:

1. `-include-hidden` un-skipped Windows `SYSTEM`-attributed files along with hidden ones, because the two attributes were tested as one mask.
2. The directory walk aborted an entire scan on any failure below the root.

3. Permission denial below the root was reported as the undifferentiated word “unreadable”, discarding the error kind.

A fourth defect was introduced and caught by the new tests rather than by review: the first integration test for `distribute` destination guarding failed because the sandbox directory lies inside the home directory on Windows, so the pre-existing overlap check rejected the pair before the guard was reached. The test was correct and the fixture was wrong, which is the desirable ordering.

10 Discussion

10.1 Threats to validity

Platform coverage of the probes. Rule tables are validated on every host, but the probe implementations are inherently platform-specific and were executed only on Windows during development. Continuous integration runs the suite on all three platforms; the macOS `st_flags` path and the Linux `mountinfo` live-read path have not been exercised by the author directly. The `mountinfo` *parser* is tested against fixtures on every host, which isolates the untested surface to the file read itself.

Soundness is empirical, not proved. P1 is a claim about a hand-maintained table, not a theorem. New operating system releases introduce directories; the mitigation is the layered composition of name rules, environment variables, runtime attributes and the writability probe, such that a path missing from the table is often still caught by a fact. We make no completeness claim.

Precision is measured against a curated corpus. The 24-directory negative corpus reflects the author’s judgement about what is ordinary. A field study of real invocations would be a stronger instrument and was not conducted.

Time-of-check-to-time-of-use. The classifier judges a directory that could in principle be replaced before the operation proceeds. We consider this acceptable: the guard defends against user error, not against a local adversary who could simply run the tool themselves.

10.2 Generality

The mechanisms are not specific to file organizers. The pure-classifier-plus-facts structure applies to any tool that must judge a target before acting on it; the platform-as-parameter technique applies to any cross-platform path logic and is, we think, underused; the survival taxonomy with one stated fatal exception applies to any bulk operation; and the observation that a move journal cannot express directory deletion applies to any reversible operation that removes containers.

10.3 Future work

Four directions follow directly. Effective-UID comparison via `rustix` would complete the ownership signal at the cost of one pure-Rust dependency. A TZif parser would remove the time-zone limitation without a date crate. Per-move instrumentation could be added by way of an observer trait on the executor, which was designed but not implemented, on the grounds that the journal already carries the same information. Finally, the negative corpus should be extended empirically rather than by judgement, which would require telemetry the tool deliberately does not collect — an instructive tension between measurement and the project’s privacy stance.

11 Conclusion

Bulk file reorganization is a category of tool whose core mechanism is indifferent to the value of what it operates on. We have described a guard that closes that gap across Windows, macOS and Linux, built around a pure classifier whose platform is an argument, so that all three rule tables are validated from any host; an empirical writability probe that is correct where mode bits, ACLs and System Integrity Protection disagree; a survival architecture with exactly one stated fatal exception; and an idempotent re-grouping operation whose undo restores directory structure, not merely file locations.

Two lessons generalize beyond the artifact. The first is that precision is a safety property: a guard that fires on `D:\Downloads` teaches users to bypass it and protects nobody, which is why two plausible rules were deliberately weakened and why a negative corpus is part of the test suite rather than an afterthought. The second is that separating a pure verdict from an impure policy is what made the work testable at all — and that the same separation forced the discovery, in the Rust standard library, that `std::path` cannot be used to reason about another platform's paths.

The implementation is 5,633 lines, adds no dependencies, and passes 350 tests.

Availability

The implementation is open source at <https://github.com/ianktoo/tidy-up>, released under the MIT licence together with a supplementary end-user licence. The modules described here are `src/safety.rs`, `src/outcome.rs`, `src/regroup.rs`, `src/obs.rs` and `src/commands/guard.rs`, with tests in the corresponding `*_tests.rs` files and in `tests/`.

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